

Late Gothic

During the course of the 13th century the Gothic style grew more daring and coherent. Refinements to arches, vaults and buttresses permitted complex floor plans and huge cathedrals, with large, sculptural windows bearing elaborate tracery and fine stained glass. In France, after the collapse of Beauvais cathedral in 1284, with its ambitiously high nave – a record-breaking 48 metres (157 ft) – architects focused less on size, more on refinements in decoration. From the 14th century, Rayonnant gave way to the Flamboyant style, named after its extravagant, flame-shaped tracery. Pinnacles, mouldings and windows became more intricate, and columns slimmer. The abbey church of Saint-Denis was largely rebuilt, and Chartres cathedral and Notre Dame were given elaborate new façades. Beyond France, the high choir of Cologne cathedral (1248–1322, opposite) is one of the best German examples of Rayonnant, while Antwerp cathedral (consecrated 1521) is a late Gothic building with huge stained-glass clerestory windows; its single soaring tower was intended to have a twin, which was never completed.

